



Zone-by-Zone Seed Starting Calendar

Month-by-month planting schedules for USDA Zones 3–10

\$18 (Complete Bundle)

Open-pollinated • Community-grown • Food sovereignty for everyone

Zone-by-Zone Seed Starting Calendar

USDA Hardiness Zones 3-10 | Complete Planting Guide

By Seedwarden

You bought seeds. Good. Now the question is when to actually put them in dirt — and that answer changes depending on where you live.

This calendar tells you exactly when to start seeds indoors, when to move them outside, and when to direct sow — month by month, for your specific USDA zone. No guessing. No "plant after danger of frost has passed" without telling you when that actually is. Real dates, real varieties, real spacing.

This is the calendar corporate seed packets should give you but don't, because they'd rather sell you the same generic instructions whether you're in Minneapolis or Mobile.

What you're getting:

- Month-by-month planting schedules for 45+ vegetables, herbs, and companion flowers
- Indoor start dates with weeks-before-last-frost counts
- Transplant timing with hardening off notes
- Direct sow windows with soil temperature requirements
- Named heirloom and open-pollinated variety recommendations
- Season extension strategies specific to your climate
- Frost date ranges for major cities in your zone

Pricing:

- Individual zone: \$7
- Complete bundle (Zones 3-10): \$18

Disclaimer

This calendar is educational content based on widely accepted horticultural data, USDA hardiness zone classifications, and accumulated growing experience. It is not professional agricultural advice. Microclimates, elevation, urban heat islands, annual weather variation, and soil conditions all affect real-world outcomes. Your actual last frost date may differ from averages. When in doubt, contact your local cooperative extension office — they're publicly funded, underused, and full of people who actually know your specific area.

Seedwarden is not responsible for crop failures. Gardening involves risk. That's part of the deal.

How to Use This Calendar

Step 1: Find Your Zone

Look up your USDA Hardiness Zone at planthardiness.ars.usda.gov or check the zone map reference below. Your zone is based on average annual minimum winter temperature, and it determines your frost dates and growing season length.

Step 2: Understand the Format

Each zone section gives you three categories per month:

- Indoor Start — Seeds to start in trays/pots under lights or in a sunny window. Listed as "X weeks before last frost" so you can adjust to your exact microclimate.
- Transplant Outdoors — Seedlings (started indoors or purchased) ready to move outside. Includes hardening off notes.
- Direct Sow — Seeds planted straight into garden soil. Includes minimum soil temperature.

Step 3: Adjust for Your Microclimate

South-facing walls, raised beds, and urban settings run warmer. North-facing slopes, valleys, and exposed sites run colder. If you're on the edge of two zones, read both and split the difference.

Symbols

- (H) — Heirloom variety
- (OP) — Open-pollinated (non-hybrid, seed-saveable)
- ST: — Minimum soil temperature for germination

USDA Zone Map Reference

Zone	Avg. Annual Min. Temp	Primary Regions
3	-40 to -30 F	Northern Minnesota, Wisconsin, Montana,
4	-30 to -20 F	Upper Midwest, northern New England, Wyo
5	-20 to -10 F	Southern New England, Iowa, Missouri Oza
6	-10 to 0 F	Mid-Atlantic, southern Ohio Valley, cent
7	0 to 10 F	Virginia Piedmont, Tennessee, Oklahoma,
8	10 to 20 F	Coastal Pacific Northwest, central Texas
9	20 to 30 F	Southern Texas, central Florida, Souther
10	30 to 40 F	South Florida, coastal Southern Californ

Zone 3 — Northern Plains, Mountain Interior & Upper Great Lakes

Last frost date (average): May 15 - June 1

First frost date (average): September 5 - September 20

Growing season length: 95-125 days

Key challenges: Extremely short season, late springs, early falls, deep soil freeze, intense winter, wind exposure

Season extension tips: Wall O' Waters for tomatoes and peppers starting 2-3 weeks before last frost. Low tunnels and cold frames extend fall harvest 3-6 weeks. Mulch heavily after soil warms. Choose short-season varieties for everything — this is non-negotiable.

January

Indoor Start This Month:

- Onion (from seed) — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Walla Walla (OP), Ailsa Craig (OP) — long-day varieties only in Zone 3; use grow lights 14-16 hours
- Leek — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — American Flag (H), King Richard (OP) — slow grower, start early
- Celery — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Utah Tall (H), Tango (OP) — needs light to germinate, do not cover seed

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Nothing. The ground is frozen solid.

Direct Sow This Month:

- Nothing outdoors.
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February

Indoor Start This Month:

- Pepper (sweet) — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — King of the North (OP), Ace (OP) — peppers need consistent 75-85 F for germination; use a heat mat
- Pepper (hot) — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Hungarian Hot Wax (H), Early Jalapeno (OP) — hot peppers are slower, start before sweets
- Eggplant — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — Rosa Bianca (H), Black Beauty (H) — needs warmth; 80-85 F bottom heat
- Parsley — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — Italian Flat Leaf (OP) — soak seed 24 hours, slow to germinate

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Nothing.

Direct Sow This Month:

- Nothing outdoors.
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March

Indoor Start This Month:

- Tomato — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Stupice (OP), Glacier (OP), Sub Arctic Plenty (OP) — short-season varieties essential; 65-70 day varieties work best
- Broccoli — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Waltham 29 (H), De Cicco (H) — cool-season crop, transplant before heat arrives
- Cauliflower — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Snowball Self-Blanching (H), Amazing (OP) — fussier than broccoli, keep temps 60-70 F
- Cabbage — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Copenhagen Market (H), Early Jersey Wakefield (H) — cold-tolerant once established
- Brussels sprouts — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Long Island Improved (H) — needs full season; start early
- Swiss chard — start 4-6 weeks before last frost — Fordhook Giant (H), Rainbow (OP) — or direct sow later
- Kale — start 4-6 weeks before last frost — Dwarf Blue Curled (H), Lacinato (H) — extremely cold-hardy
- Basil — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Genovese (OP), Italian Large Leaf (OP) — do not rush outside, zero frost tolerance
- Thyme — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — Common Thyme (OP) — slow germinator
- Oregano — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — Greek Oregano (OP) — tiny seeds, surface sow
- Sage — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — Common Sage (OP) — perennial, worth the long start

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Nothing yet.

Direct Sow This Month:

- Nothing outdoors.
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April

Indoor Start This Month:

- Cucumber — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Marketmore 76 (OP), National Pickling (H) — don't start too early, cucurbits resent transplanting
- Squash (summer) — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Black Beauty Zucchini (OP), Yellow Crookneck (H)
- Squash (winter) — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Butternut Waltham (H), Table Queen Acorn (H) — choose 85-95 day varieties
- Zucchini — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Dark Star (OP), Costata Romanesco (H)
- Pumpkin — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Small Sugar (H), Jack Be Little (OP) — short-season pumpkins only; skip Atlantic Giant
- Melon — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Minnesota Midget (H), Delicious 51 (H) — melons are a gamble in Zone 3; use black plastic mulch
- Watermelon — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Sugar Baby (OP), Blacktail Mountain (OP) — 70-75 day varieties only
- Corn — start indoors in soil blocks 2-3 weeks before last frost (optional) — or direct sow after frost
- Dill — start 4 weeks before last frost — Bouquet (OP) — or direct sow, doesn't transplant well
- Cilantro — start 4 weeks before last frost — Santo (OP), Slow Bolt (OP) — bolts fast in heat

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Nothing yet — still frost risk through mid-May at minimum.

Direct Sow This Month:

- Peas — as soon as soil is workable, ST: 40 F — Alaska (H), Little Marvel (H) — 2 inches apart, 1 inch deep; can handle frost
- Spinach — as soon as soil is workable, ST: 35 F — Bloomsdale Long Standing (H), Giant Noble (H) — direct sow thickly, thin to 4 inches
- Radish — as soon as soil is workable, ST: 40 F — Cherry Belle (OP), French Breakfast (H) — 1 inch apart, half inch deep; 25-day crop

May

Indoor Start This Month:

- Nasturtium — start 2-3 weeks before last frost — Jewel Mix (OP) — or direct sow after frost; edible flowers, trap crop for aphids
- Sunflower — start 2 weeks before last frost (optional) — Mammoth Russian (H) — direct sow preferred

Transplant Outdoors This Month (after last frost, mid to late May):

- Tomato — harden off 7-10 days; protect with Wall O' Water if planting before last frost — plant deep, burying stem to first true leaves
- Pepper (sweet + hot) — harden off 10-14 days; wait until night temps consistently above 50 F — do not rush peppers
- Eggplant — harden off 7-10 days; needs warm soil above 65 F — use black plastic mulch
- Broccoli — harden off 5-7 days; can go out 2 weeks before last frost — tolerates light frost
- Cauliflower — harden off 5-7 days — more sensitive to cold snaps than broccoli
- Cabbage — harden off 5-7 days; tolerates frost to 28 F once hardened
- Brussels sprouts — harden off 5-7 days
- Kale — harden off 5-7 days; very frost-tolerant once established
- Swiss chard — harden off 5-7 days
- Lettuce — harden off 5-7 days — or direct sow
- Celery — harden off 7-10 days; needs rich, consistently moist soil
- Onion (transplants/sets) — plant sets or transplants as soon as soil is workable
- Leek — harden off 5-7 days; plant in trenches 6 inches deep
- Basil — after all frost danger; night temps above 50 F — basil blackens at first hint of cold
- Parsley — harden off 5-7 days
- Thyme, Oregano, Sage — harden off 5-7 days; perennials, plant once and done

Direct Sow This Month (mid to late May):

- Beans (bush) — after last frost, ST: 60 F — Provider (OP), Contender (H) — 3 inches apart, 1 inch deep; do not soak
- Beans (pole) — after last frost, ST: 60 F — Kentucky Wonder (H), Rattlesnake (H) — provide trellis at planting
- Corn — after last frost, ST: 60 F — Golden Bantam (H), Stowell's Evergreen (H) — plant in blocks of at least 4 rows for pollination, 10-12 inches apart
- Lettuce — ST: 40 F — Black Seeded Simpson (OP), Buttercrunch (H) — succession sow every 2 weeks
- Arugula — ST: 40 F — Astro (OP), Sylvestra/Wild (OP) — bolts in heat, sow thickly
- Beets — ST: 50 F — Detroit Dark Red (H), Chioggia (H) — soak seed 12 hours; each seed cluster produces multiple seedlings, thin to 3 inches
- Carrots — ST: 50 F — Scarlet Nantes (H), Danvers Half Long (H) — keep soil moist until germination (10-21 days); do not let surface crust
- Turnip — ST: 40 F — Purple Top White Globe (H) — 2 inches apart, thin to 4 inches
- Dill — ST: 60 F — Bouquet (OP) — direct sow preferred
- Chives — ST: 60 F — Common Chives (OP) — perennial, direct sow or transplant divisions
- Potato — plant seed potatoes 2-3 weeks before last frost — Yukon Gold (OP), Red Norland (OP) — cut pieces with 2-3 eyes, cure 24 hours before planting, 12 inches apart, 4 inches deep

- Marigold — after last frost, ST: 65 F — Sparky Mix (OP) — companion plant, pest deterrent
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June

Indoor Start This Month:

- Succession lettuce and cilantro for fall transplant (late June)

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Melon — harden off 5-7 days; black plastic mulch and row cover essential in Zone 3
- Watermelon — same as melon; remove row cover at flowering for pollination
- Sweet potato — plant slips after soil reaches 65 F — Beauregard (OP), Georgia Jet (OP) — Zone 3 is marginal; use black plastic mulch and choose 90-day varieties
- Any remaining warm-season transplants from May

Direct Sow This Month:

- Cucumber — ST: 65 F — Marketmore 76 (OP) — or transplant; 12 inches apart on trellis
 - Squash (summer) — ST: 65 F — hills 3 feet apart
 - Squash (winter) — ST: 65 F — hills 4 feet apart; choose short-season varieties
 - Zucchini — ST: 65 F — 3 feet apart
 - Pumpkin — ST: 65 F — hills 5 feet apart
 - Beans (bush) — succession sow, ST: 60 F
 - Okra — ST: 65 F — Clemson Spineless (H) — Zone 3 is marginal; use black plastic and row cover, choose early varieties
 - Sunflower — ST: 55 F — Mammoth Russian (H) — 18 inches apart
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July

Indoor Start This Month:

- Broccoli (fall crop) — start 8-10 weeks before first frost — midsummer start for fall harvest
- Kale (fall crop) — start 6-8 weeks before first frost
- Cabbage (fall crop) — start 8-10 weeks before first frost — choose fast varieties

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Succession lettuce — under shade cloth if temps above 80 F

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beans (bush) — last succession sow by July 1 — need 55-60 days to mature
 - Lettuce — ST: 40 F — shade cloth helpful; fall crop
 - Carrots — succession sow by July 1 for fall harvest
 - Beets — succession sow for fall
 - Cilantro — cooler weather coming means less bolting
 - Dill — succession sow
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August

Indoor Start This Month:

- Nothing — too late for indoor starts in Zone 3

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Broccoli (fall) — transplant early August; will mature before hard frost
- Kale (fall) — transplant; frost improves flavor
- Cabbage (fall) — transplant early August

Direct Sow This Month:

- Spinach — fall crop, ST: 35 F — direct sow early August; harvest before hard freeze
 - Radish — ST: 40 F — 25-day crop, sow through mid-August
 - Arugula — fall crop, will handle light frost
 - Lettuce — fall crop under row cover
 - Turnip — sow early August for fall harvest
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September

Indoor Start This Month:

- Nothing.

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Nothing new.

Direct Sow This Month:

- Garlic — plant cloves 4-6 weeks before ground freezes (mid-September to early October in Zone 3) — Music (H, hardneck), German Extra Hardy (H, hardneck) — hardneck varieties only; plant 6 inches apart, 2-3 inches deep, mulch heavily with 4-6 inches straw after ground freezes
- Spinach — can overwinter under heavy mulch for very early spring harvest

Harvest focus: Tomatoes, peppers, squash, beans, corn. Watch frost forecasts nightly. Harvest all tender crops before first frost. Green tomatoes ripen indoors.

October

Direct Sow This Month:

- Garlic — finish planting by mid-October, before ground freezes

Harvest focus: Pull remaining root crops before hard ground freeze. Cure winter squash and pumpkins. Dig potatoes after vines die back. Cut and dry herbs.

Season extension: Low tunnels and cold frames keep spinach, kale, lettuce, and arugula alive well into November.

November - December

The ground is frozen or freezing. Garden is done. Mulch garlic beds. Review your notes. Order seed catalogs. Plan next year.

Frost date reference — Zone 3 cities:

- International Falls, MN: Last frost May 21, First frost Sept 14
- Duluth, MN: Last frost May 21, First frost Sept 25
- Bismarck, ND: Last frost May 14, First frost Sept 22

Zone 4 — Upper Midwest, Northern New England & Mountain Valleys

Last frost date (average): May 5 - May 25

First frost date (average): September 15 - October 5

Growing season length: 120-150 days

Key challenges: Short season, late spring warm-up, cold soil persistence, heavy snow winters, variable spring weather

Season extension tips: Cold frames add 4-6 weeks on both ends. Row cover (Agribon 19) protects transplants to 28 F. Raised beds warm faster in spring — 1-2 week advantage over in-ground.

January

Indoor Start This Month:

- Onion (from seed) — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Copra (OP), Yellow of Parma (H) — long-day varieties; grow lights essential
- Leek — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — American Flag (H), Giant Musselburgh (H)
- Celery — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Tall Utah (H), Ventura (OP)

Transplant/Direct Sow: Nothing.

February

Indoor Start This Month:

- Pepper (sweet) — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — California Wonder (H), King of the North (OP)
- Pepper (hot) — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Cayenne Long Slim (H), Hungarian Hot Wax (H)
- Eggplant — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — Black Beauty (H), Listada de Gandia (H)
- Parsley — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — Italian Flat Leaf (OP)
- Rosemary — start from seed 10-12 weeks before last frost — Common Rosemary (OP) — very slow germination; easier from cuttings or purchased plant; grow as annual or overwinter indoors

Transplant/Direct Sow: Nothing.

March

Indoor Start This Month:

- Tomato — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Brandywine (H), Cherokee Purple (H), Early Girl (OP), Stupice (OP) — wider variety selection than Zone 3
- Broccoli — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Calabrese (H), Waltham 29 (H)
- Cauliflower — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Snowball (H), Purple of Sicily (H)
- Cabbage — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Early Jersey Wakefield (H), Red Acre (H)
- Brussels sprouts — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Long Island Improved (H), Catskill (H)
- Swiss chard — start 4-6 weeks before last frost — Fordhook Giant (H), Five Color Silverbeet (H)
- Kale — start 4-6 weeks before last frost — Red Russian (OP), Lacinato (H)
- Basil — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Genovese (OP), Purple Ruffles (OP)
- Thyme — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — English Thyme (OP)
- Oregano — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — Greek Oregano (OP)
- Sage — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — Broadleaf (OP)
- Lavender — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Munstead (OP), Hidcote (OP) — cold-stratify seed 2 weeks before sowing; slow germinator

Transplant/Direct Sow: Nothing outdoors.

April

Indoor Start This Month:

- Cucumber — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Straight Eight (H), Boston Pickling (H)
- Squash (summer/winter), Zucchini, Pumpkin, Melon, Watermelon — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — same variety recommendations as Zone 3
- Corn — optional indoor start in soil blocks, 2-3 weeks before last frost
- Dill — start 4 weeks before last frost — Mammoth (OP)
- Cilantro — start 4 weeks before last frost — Santo (OP)
- Nasturtium — start 2-3 weeks before last frost — Empress of India (H)
- Marigold — start 4-6 weeks before last frost — Crackerjack Mix (OP)

Transplant Outdoors This Month (late April, under row cover):

- Peas — transplant or direct sow; cold tolerant
- Onion sets — plant as soon as soil is workable
- Potato — plant seed potatoes 2-3 weeks before last frost

Direct Sow This Month (mid to late April):

- Peas — ST: 40 F — Alderman/Tall Telephone (H), Green Arrow (OP) — inoculant helps
 - Spinach — ST: 35 F — Bloomsdale Long Standing (H), Tyee (OP)
 - Radish — ST: 40 F — Cherry Belle (OP), Easter Egg (OP)
 - Lettuce — ST: 40 F — Parris Island Cos (H), Red Sails (OP)
 - Arugula — ST: 40 F — Astro (OP)
 - Turnip — ST: 40 F — Purple Top White Globe (H)
 - Kale — direct sow option, ST: 40 F
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May

Indoor Start This Month:

- Sunflower — start 2 weeks before last frost or direct sow

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Tomato — after last frost (mid-May), harden off 7-10 days
- Pepper (sweet + hot) — after last frost, night temps above 50 F
- Eggplant — after last frost, soil above 65 F
- Broccoli, Cauliflower, Cabbage, Brussels sprouts — harden off 5-7 days; can go out early May under row cover
- Swiss chard, Kale — harden off 5-7 days
- Lettuce starts — harden off 5-7 days
- Celery — after frost danger, rich moist soil
- Onion transplants, Leek — plant out mid-May
- Basil — after all frost danger, night temps above 50 F
- Parsley, Thyme, Oregano, Sage, Rosemary — harden off 5-7 days
- Lavender — harden off 7-10 days; full sun, well-drained soil

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beans (bush) — after last frost, ST: 60 F — Tendergreen (H), Provider (OP)
 - Beans (pole) — after last frost, ST: 60 F — Blue Lake (OP), Scarlet Runner (H)
 - Corn — after last frost, ST: 60 F — Golden Bantam (H), Country Gentleman (H) — blocks not rows
 - Beets — ST: 50 F — Detroit Dark Red (H), Bull's Blood (H)
 - Carrots — ST: 50 F — Scarlet Nantes (H), Chantenay Red Core (H)
 - Dill — ST: 60 F — Bouquet (OP)
 - Chives — ST: 60 F — perennial
 - Marigold — after frost, ST: 65 F
 - Potato — if not planted in April
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June

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Cucumber, Squash, Zucchini — harden off 5-7 days; after soil warms
- Melon, Watermelon — black plastic mulch and row cover recommended
- Pumpkin — transplant or direct sow
- Sweet potato — plant slips after soil reaches 65 F — Beauregard (OP), Covington (OP) — use black plastic; Zone 4 is marginal but doable

Direct Sow This Month:

- Cucumber — ST: 65 F — 12 inches apart
 - Squash (summer + winter) — ST: 65 F
 - Zucchini — ST: 65 F
 - Pumpkin — ST: 65 F — Connecticut Field (H), Small Sugar (H)
 - Beans — succession sow
 - Okra — ST: 65 F — Clemson Spineless (H) — marginal; needs hottest spot, black plastic
 - Sunflower — ST: 55 F — Mammoth Russian (H), Velvet Queen (OP)
 - Nasturtium — ST: 55 F
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July

Indoor Start This Month:

- Broccoli (fall) — start 8-10 weeks before first frost
- Kale (fall) — start 6-8 weeks before first frost
- Cabbage (fall) — start 6-8 weeks before first frost

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beans (bush) — last succession sow by mid-July
 - Carrots — succession sow by July 1
 - Beets — succession sow for fall
 - Lettuce — fall crop, shade cloth over 80 F
 - Cilantro — cooler nights reduce bolting
 - Dill — succession sow
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August

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Fall broccoli, kale, cabbage — transplant early to mid-August

Direct Sow This Month:

- Spinach — fall crop, early August
 - Radish — sow through late August
 - Arugula — fall crop
 - Lettuce — under row cover for frost protection
 - Turnip — sow early August
 - Peas (fall) — sow early August for October harvest
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September

Direct Sow This Month:

- Garlic — plant mid-September to mid-October — Music (H), German White (H) — hardneck varieties; 6 inches apart, 3 inches deep, mulch after ground freezes
- Spinach — overwintering sow under cold frame

Harvest focus: Cure winter squash. Pull all tender crops before frost. Green tomatoes ripen indoors wrapped in newspaper.

October - December

Harvest root crops before hard freeze. Mulch garlic. Put garden to bed. Compost spent plants (not diseased ones). Rest.

Frost date reference — Zone 4 cities:

- Minneapolis, MN: Last frost May 5, First frost Oct 4
- Burlington, VT: Last frost May 10, First frost Oct 1
- Madison, WI: Last frost May 5, First frost Oct 3

Zone 5 — Central Corridor, Southern New England & Mid-Elevation West

Last frost date (average): April 15 - May 10

First frost date (average): October 1 - October 20

Growing season length: 150-180 days

Key challenges: Highly variable spring, late cold snaps, clay soils in Midwest, summer humidity promoting disease

Season extension tips: Unheated hoop house extends season 6-8 weeks on each end. Succession planting is key — you have time for spring and fall crops of most cool-season vegetables.

January - February

Indoor Start (February):

- Onion (from seed) — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Ailsa Craig (OP), Walla Walla (OP)
 - Leek — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — King Richard (OP)
 - Celery — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Tall Utah (H)
 - Pepper (sweet) — start late Feb, 8-10 weeks before last frost — California Wonder (H), Jimmy Nardello (H)
 - Pepper (hot) — start late Feb, 10-12 weeks before last frost — Fish Pepper (H), Serrano (OP)
 - Eggplant — start late Feb, 8-10 weeks before last frost — Black Beauty (H), Rosa Bianca (H)
 - Parsley — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — Italian Giant (OP)
 - Rosemary — start from seed 10-12 weeks before last frost (slow) — or buy a plant
 - Lavender — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Munstead (OP) — cold stratify first
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March

Indoor Start This Month:

- Tomato — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Brandywine (H), San Marzano (H), Mortgage Lifter (H), Cherokee Purple (H), Rutgers (H) — full heirloom range available
- Broccoli — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Calabrese (H), De Cicco (H)
- Cauliflower — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Snowball (H), Amazing (OP)
- Cabbage — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Early Jersey Wakefield (H), January King (H)
- Brussels sprouts — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Long Island Improved (H)
- Swiss chard — start 4-6 weeks before last frost — Bright Lights (OP), Fordhook Giant (H)
- Kale — start 4-6 weeks before last frost — Lacinato (H), Winterbor (OP)
- Basil — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Genovese (OP), Thai (OP)
- Oregano, Thyme, Sage — start 8-10 weeks before last frost

Direct Sow This Month (late March, if soil workable):

- Peas — ST: 40 F — Sugar Snap (OP), Lincoln (H) — as early as soil can be worked
 - Spinach — ST: 35 F — Bloomsdale (H), Corvair (OP)
 - Radish — ST: 40 F — Cherry Belle (OP)
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April

Indoor Start This Month:

- Cucumber — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Marketmore 76 (OP), Lemon (H)
- Squash, Zucchini, Pumpkin, Melon, Watermelon — start 3-4 weeks before last frost
- Nasturtium, Marigold, Sunflower — start 3-4 weeks before last frost

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Broccoli, Cauliflower, Cabbage — harden off 5-7 days; mid-April; frost tolerant
- Kale, Swiss chard, Lettuce — harden off 5-7 days
- Onion sets and transplants — as soon as soil is workable
- Leek — transplant mid-to-late April
- Potato — plant seed potatoes early to mid-April — Kennebec (OP), Yukon Gold (OP), All Blue (OP)
- Parsley — harden off 5-7 days

Direct Sow This Month:

- Peas — if not sown in March
 - Lettuce — ST: 40 F — Buttercrunch (H), Jericho (OP) — succession sow every 2 weeks
 - Arugula — ST: 40 F — Astro (OP)
 - Beets — ST: 50 F — Cylindra (OP), Detroit Dark Red (H)
 - Carrots — ST: 50 F — Scarlet Nantes (H), Danvers (H), Cosmic Purple (OP)
 - Turnip — ST: 40 F — Purple Top White Globe (H)
 - Radish — succession sow
 - Spinach — succession sow
 - Dill — ST: 60 F — Bouquet (OP)
 - Cilantro — ST: 50 F — Santo (OP)
 - Chives — ST: 60 F
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May

Transplant Outdoors This Month (after last frost):

- Tomato — mid-May, harden off 7-10 days — plant deep
- Pepper (sweet + hot) — after last frost, night temps above 50 F
- Eggplant — after last frost, soil above 65 F
- Basil — after all frost danger
- Celery — after frost danger
- Cucumber, Squash, Zucchini — late May
- Melon, Watermelon — late May with row cover
- Sweet potato — late May, slips planted after soil reaches 65 F — Beauregard (OP), Covington (OP)
- Oregano, Thyme, Sage, Rosemary, Lavender — after frost

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beans (bush) — after last frost, ST: 60 F — Jade (OP), Provider (OP), Dragon Tongue (H)
 - Beans (pole) — after last frost, ST: 60 F — Kentucky Wonder (H), Lazy Housewife (H)
 - Corn — after last frost, ST: 60 F — Golden Bantam (H), Silver Queen (OP) — blocks of 4+ rows
 - Cucumber — ST: 65 F — late May
 - Squash, Zucchini, Pumpkin — ST: 65 F — late May
 - Sunflower — ST: 55 F — Mammoth Russian (H)
 - Marigold — ST: 65 F
 - Nasturtium — ST: 55 F
 - Okra — ST: 65 F — Clemson Spineless (H), Burgundy (OP) — viable in Zone 5 in warm microsites
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June

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beans — succession sow
 - Corn — succession sow through early June
 - Cucumber, Squash — if not yet sown
 - Pumpkin — last chance for full-size varieties
 - Okra — direct sow if not started
 - Sunflower — succession sow for staggered bloom
-

July

Indoor Start This Month:

- Broccoli (fall) — start 8-10 weeks before first frost
- Cauliflower (fall) — start 8-10 weeks before first frost
- Cabbage (fall) — start 6-8 weeks before first frost
- Kale (fall) — start 6-8 weeks before first frost
- Brussels sprouts (fall) — if not started in spring

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beans (bush) — succession sow through mid-July
 - Carrots — succession sow by early July for fall
 - Beets — succession for fall
 - Lettuce — fall crop, shade cloth in heat
 - Cilantro — fall sowing, cooler temps
 - Dill — succession sow
-

August

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Fall broccoli, cauliflower, cabbage, kale — transplant early August

Direct Sow This Month:

- Spinach — fall crop, early August
 - Lettuce — fall crop
 - Radish — sow through September
 - Arugula — fall crop, direct sow
 - Turnip — sow for fall harvest
 - Peas (fall) — early August for October harvest
 - Cilantro — fall crop
-

September

Direct Sow This Month:

- Garlic — plant mid-September to late October — Music (H), Purple Glazer (H), Chesnok Red (H) — hardneck or softneck both work in Zone 5; 6 inches apart, 2-3 inches deep
- Spinach — overwintering under row cover or cold frame
- Radish — quick crops through mid-September

Harvest focus: Tomatoes, peppers, squash, potatoes. Frost watch begins.

October - December

Finish garlic planting by late October. Harvest remaining root crops. Mulch perennial herbs. Clean up beds. Compost. Plan.

Frost date reference — Zone 5 cities:

- Denver, CO: Last frost May 5, First frost Oct 6
- Des Moines, IA: Last frost April 24, First frost Oct 10
- Boston, MA (suburbs): Last frost April 26, First frost Oct 16

Zone 6 — Mid-Atlantic, Ohio Valley & Central Transition Zone

Last frost date (average): April 5 - April 25

First frost date (average): October 10 - November 1

Growing season length: 170-200 days

Key challenges: Summer humidity and fungal pressure, clay soils in Ohio Valley, variable spring, Japanese beetles, squash vine borers

Season extension tips: You have a long enough season for true succession planting — spring and fall rounds of brassicas, two rounds of beans, and fall peas. Floating row cover for pest exclusion as much as frost protection.

January

Indoor Start This Month:

- Onion (from seed) — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Patterson (OP), Candy (OP) — long-day or intermediate-day depending on exact location
 - Leek — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — King Richard (OP), Blue Solaise (H)
 - Celery — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Ventura (OP)
-

February

Indoor Start This Month:

- Pepper (sweet) — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — Bull Nose (H), California Wonder (H), Jimmy Nardello (H)
- Pepper (hot) — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Cayenne (H), Habanero (OP), Fish Pepper (H)
- Eggplant — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — Black Beauty (H), Ichiban (OP), Listada de Gandia (H)
- Parsley — start 8-10 weeks before last frost
- Rosemary — start from seed 10-12 weeks (or buy plant; often perennial in Zone 6b with protection)
- Lavender — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Hidcote (OP), Grosso (OP) — may perennialize in Zone 6b

Direct Sow (late February, if ground is workable):

- Peas — under row cover, ST: 40 F — can go in as early as Presidents' Day in mild years
 - Spinach — under row cover, ST: 35 F
-

March

Indoor Start This Month:

- Tomato — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Brandywine (H), Cherokee Purple (H), Mortgage Lifter (H), San Marzano (H), Rutgers (H), Black Krim (H) — full range
- Broccoli — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Calabrese (H), De Cicco (H)
- Cauliflower — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Snowball (H)
- Cabbage — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Golden Acre (H), Red Acre (H)
- Brussels sprouts — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Long Island Improved (H)
- Swiss chard — start 4-6 weeks before last frost — Fordhook Giant (H)
- Kale — start 4-6 weeks before last frost — Lacinato (H), Red Russian (OP)
- Basil — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Genovese (OP), Lemon (OP), Thai (OP)
- Oregano, Thyme, Sage — start 8-10 weeks before last frost

Direct Sow This Month:

- Peas — ST: 40 F — Sugar Snap (OP), Wando (OP) — early to mid-March
 - Spinach — ST: 35 F — direct sow
 - Radish — ST: 40 F — early March
 - Lettuce — ST: 40 F — direct sow mid-March
 - Arugula — ST: 40 F
 - Turnip — ST: 40 F
 - Carrots — ST: 50 F — late March if soil workable
 - Beets — ST: 50 F — late March
-

April

Indoor Start This Month:

- Cucumber — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Straight Eight (H), Suyo Long (OP)
- Squash, Zucchini, Pumpkin — start 3-4 weeks before last frost
- Melon — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Hale's Best Jumbo (H), Charentais (H)
- Watermelon — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Crimson Sweet (OP), Moon and Stars (H)

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Broccoli, Cauliflower, Cabbage, Brussels sprouts — early to mid-April, harden off 5-7 days
- Kale, Swiss chard — mid-April
- Lettuce transplants — mid-April
- Onion sets/transplants — early April
- Leek — mid-April
- Potato — early to mid-April — Kennebec (OP), Yukon Gold (OP), Adirondack Blue (OP)
- Celery — late April
- Parsley — mid-April
- Herbs (thyme, oregano, sage, rosemary) — late April

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beets — ST: 50 F — Detroit Dark Red (H)
- Carrots — ST: 50 F — Danvers (H), Nantes (H)
- Lettuce — succession sow every 2 weeks
- Arugula — succession sow
- Peas — last sowing for spring crop
- Dill — ST: 60 F
- Cilantro — ST: 50 F
- Chives — ST: 60 F

May

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Tomato — early to mid-May, harden off 7-10 days
- Pepper — mid-May, after night temps stabilize above 55 F
- Eggplant — mid-May, soil above 65 F
- Basil — after frost danger passes
- Cucumber, Squash, Zucchini — mid to late May
- Melon, Watermelon — late May
- Sweet potato — late May, slips after soil reaches 65 F — Beauregard (OP), Covington (OP), Japanese Purple (OP)
- Lavender — mid-May

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beans (bush + pole) — after last frost, ST: 60 F — Contender (H), Blue Lake (OP), Rattlesnake (H)
 - Corn — ST: 60 F — Golden Bantam (H), Stowell's Evergreen (H), Bloody Butcher (H)
 - Cucumber — ST: 65 F — late May
 - Squash, Zucchini — ST: 65 F
 - Pumpkin — ST: 65 F — Connecticut Field (H), Musquee de Provence (H)
 - Okra — ST: 65 F — Clemson Spineless (H), Star of David (H) — productive in Zone 6
 - Sunflower — ST: 55 F
 - Marigold — ST: 65 F
 - Nasturtium — ST: 55 F
-

June

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beans — succession sow
 - Corn — succession sow through mid-June
 - Cucumber — succession sow
 - Squash (summer) — succession sow for extended harvest
 - Pumpkin — last sowing for fall harvest
 - Melon, Watermelon — direct sow if not transplanted
-

July

Indoor Start This Month:

- Broccoli (fall) — start 8-10 weeks before first frost
- Cauliflower (fall) — start 8-10 weeks before first frost
- Cabbage (fall) — start 6-8 weeks before first frost
- Kale (fall) — direct sow or start 6-8 weeks before first frost
- Brussels sprouts — should already be in ground from spring start

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beans (bush) — succession sow through late July
 - Carrots — succession sow for fall
 - Beets — for fall harvest
 - Lettuce — fall crop, shade cloth in July heat
 - Cilantro — fall crop
 - Dill — succession sow
 - Buckwheat — cover crop in empty beds; turn under before flowering
-

August

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Fall broccoli, cauliflower, cabbage — early August
- Kale — transplant or direct sow

Direct Sow This Month:

- Spinach — fall crop, mid-August
 - Lettuce — fall crop
 - Radish — fall crop, through September
 - Arugula — fall crop
 - Turnip — mid-August
 - Peas (fall) — mid-August for November harvest
 - Beets — early August
 - Carrots — last sowing early August
 - Cilantro — fall
 - Dill — last sowing
-

September - October

Direct Sow This Month:

- Garlic — plant October through early November — Music (H), Inchelium Red (H, softneck), Chesnok Red (H) — both hardneck and softneck varieties thrive; plant 6 inches apart, 2-3 inches deep
 - Spinach — overwintering sow September; harvest through winter under row cover
 - Radish — last sowing early September
 - Lettuce — under cold frame, harvest into December
-

November - December

Mulch garlic beds after ground freezes. Plant cover crops (winter rye, crimson clover). Clean up. Order seeds.

Frost date reference — Zone 6 cities:

- St. Louis, MO: Last frost April 10, First frost Oct 18
- Philadelphia, PA: Last frost April 10, First frost Oct 24
- Kansas City, MO: Last frost April 9, First frost Oct 22

Zone 7 — Piedmont South, Oklahoma, North Texas & Maritime Northwest

Last frost date (average): March 22 - April 15

First frost date (average): October 20 - November 10

Growing season length: 190-225 days

Key challenges: Summer heat and humidity (Southeast), fire ants, squash vine borers, late-season hurricanes (coastal), clay soils (Piedmont)

Season extension tips: Focus shifts from extending into cold to extending through heat. Shade cloth (30-50%) protects cool-season crops through early summer and enables fall planting earlier. Two full growing seasons possible: cool season and warm season.

January

Indoor Start This Month:

- Onion (from seed) — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Walla Walla (OP), Texas Early Grano (OP) — intermediate or short-day varieties for southern Zone 7
- Leek — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — King Richard (OP)
- Celery — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Tall Utah (H)
- Pepper (sweet) — start 8-10 weeks before last frost (late Jan) — Corno di Toro (H), California Wonder (H)
- Pepper (hot) — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Ancho Poblano (H), Serrano (OP), Carolina Cayenne (OP)
- Eggplant — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — Black Beauty (H), Ping Tung Long (OP)
- Parsley — start 8-10 weeks before last frost

Direct Sow This Month (in mild years or under cover):

- Peas — ST: 40 F — can go in late January in Zone 7b; Wando (OP) handles warmer springs
 - Spinach — ST: 35 F — under row cover
-

February

Indoor Start This Month:

- Tomato — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Brandywine (H), Cherokee Purple (H), Mortgage Lifter (H), Amish Paste (H), Homestead (OP)
- Broccoli — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Calabrese (H), De Cicco (H)
- Cauliflower — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Snowball (H)
- Cabbage — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Charleston Wakefield (H), Brunswick (H)
- Brussels sprouts — start 6-8 weeks before last frost
- Swiss chard — start 4-6 weeks before last frost
- Kale — start 4-6 weeks before last frost — Lacinato (H), Red Russian (OP)
- Basil — start 6-8 weeks before last frost

Direct Sow This Month:

- Peas — ST: 40 F — Sugar Snap (OP), Oregon Sugar Pod (OP)
 - Spinach — ST: 35 F
 - Radish — ST: 40 F
 - Lettuce — ST: 40 F — under row cover for cold snaps
 - Arugula — ST: 40 F
 - Carrots — ST: 50 F — late February
 - Turnip — ST: 40 F
 - Potato — late February in Zone 7b — Yukon Gold (OP), Red Pontiac (OP)
-

March

Indoor Start This Month:

- Cucumber — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Ashley (H), Marketmore 76 (OP)
- Squash, Zucchini, Pumpkin — start 3-4 weeks before last frost
- Melon — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Hale's Best (H), Charentais (H)
- Watermelon — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Crimson Sweet (OP), Charleston Gray (H), Moon and Stars (H)

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Broccoli, Cauliflower, Cabbage — early March, harden off 5-7 days; get them in early, they bolt in heat
- Kale, Swiss chard — early March
- Lettuce — early March
- Onion sets/transplants — early March
- Leek — mid-March
- Celery — late March
- Potato — early to mid-March (Zone 7a)
- Parsley — mid-March

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beets — ST: 50 F — Chioggia (H), Cylindra (OP)
 - Carrots — ST: 50 F — Danvers (H), Chantenay (H)
 - Lettuce — succession sow every 2 weeks
 - Dill — ST: 60 F
 - Cilantro — ST: 50 F — will bolt once heat arrives
 - Chives — ST: 60 F
-

April

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Tomato — after last frost (late March to mid-April), harden off 7-10 days
- Pepper — after last frost, night temps above 55 F
- Eggplant — after last frost, soil above 65 F
- Basil — after frost danger
- Cucumber — late April
- Sweet potato — late April in Zone 7b after soil reaches 65 F — Beauregard (OP), Covington (OP)
- Herbs (thyme, oregano, sage, rosemary, lavender) — mid-April; rosemary and lavender often perennial in Zone 7

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beans (bush + pole) — after last frost, ST: 60 F — Contender (H), Kentucky Wonder (H), Rattlesnake (H)
 - Corn — ST: 60 F — Truckers Favorite (H), Golden Bantam (H), Hickory King (H)
 - Cucumber — ST: 65 F — late April
 - Squash, Zucchini — ST: 65 F — late April
 - Okra — ST: 65 F — Clemson Spineless (H), Hill Country Red (OP), Star of David (H) — excellent Zone 7 crop
 - Sunflower — ST: 55 F
 - Marigold — ST: 65 F
 - Nasturtium — ST: 55 F
-

May

Transplant/Direct Sow This Month:

- Melon, Watermelon — transplant or direct sow early May
- Pumpkin — direct sow, ST: 65 F — Musquee de Provence (H), Long Island Cheese (H)
- Sweet potato — plant slips (Zone 7a)
- Beans — succession sow
- Corn — succession sow
- Squash (winter) — direct sow — Butternut Waltham (H), Seminole Pumpkin (H)
- Cucumber — succession sow

Cool season wrap-up: Harvest remaining lettuce, spinach, peas, broccoli, cauliflower before heat hits. Peas finish by late May in most of Zone 7.

June

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beans — succession sow through June
 - Corn — last succession sow
 - Southern peas/cowpeas — ST: 65 F — a better summer option than regular peas
 - Okra — succession sow
 - Sunflower — succession sow
-

July

Indoor Start This Month:

- Broccoli (fall) — start late July, 8-10 weeks before first frost
- Cauliflower (fall) — start late July
- Cabbage (fall) — start late July
- Brussels sprouts (fall) — start early July for November harvest

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beans (bush) — last succession sow
 - Corn — last sowing early July (may not mature depending on frost date)
 - Cucumber — succession sow for fall harvest
-

August

Indoor Start This Month:

- Kale (fall) — start early August or direct sow
- Lettuce (fall) — start indoors where it's cooler, transplant when temps drop

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Fall broccoli, cauliflower, cabbage — transplant mid to late August
- Brussels sprouts — transplant mid-August

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beans (bush) — last sowing early August (60 days to harvest)
 - Carrots — fall crop, mid-August
 - Beets — fall crop, mid-August
 - Turnip — mid to late August
 - Cucumber — fall crop early August
 - Squash (summer) — fall crop early August
-

September

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Kale — transplant
- Lettuce — transplant

Direct Sow This Month:

- Spinach — ST: 35 F — fall crop, direct sow September
 - Lettuce — fall crop, direct sow
 - Radish — fall crop
 - Arugula — fall crop
 - Peas (fall) — early September
 - Turnip — early September
 - Cilantro — fall sowing
 - Dill — fall sowing
-

October - November

Direct Sow This Month:

- Garlic — plant October through November — Inchelium Red (H, softneck), Silver White (H, softneck), Music (H, hardneck) — softneck varieties do well in Zone 7; 6 inches apart, 2 inches deep
- Spinach — overwintering sow October
- Peas (overwintering) — late October in Zone 7b; mulch well

Harvest focus: Sweet potatoes after first light frost. Fall brassicas sweeten after frost. Greens produce through November and beyond under cover.

December

Harvest overwintering greens under row cover. Plant garlic if not yet done. Minimal maintenance.

Frost date reference — Zone 7 cities:

- Raleigh, NC: Last frost April 6, First frost Oct 28
- Oklahoma City, OK: Last frost April 1, First frost Nov 3
- Seattle, WA (inland suburbs): Last frost March 24, First frost Nov 11

Zone 8 — Deep South, Coastal Pacific Northwest & Central Texas

Last frost date (average): March 5 - March 25

First frost date (average): November 1 - November 25

Growing season length: 225-265 days

Key challenges: Extreme summer heat (South/Texas), drought (Texas), heavy rain and humidity (Southeast), fire ants, nematodes, fungal diseases, warm winters insufficient for some chill-hour crops

Season extension tips: The challenge here is surviving summer, not winter. Shade cloth (50%) over cool-season crops. Plant heat-tolerant varieties. The fall garden is often more productive than spring in the Deep South. Consider the "summer doldrums" — July/August may be too hot for much besides okra, sweet potato, and Southern peas.

January

Indoor Start This Month:

- Pepper (sweet) — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — Bull Nose (H), California Wonder (H), Corno di Toro (H)
- Pepper (hot) — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Cayenne (H), Tabasco (H), Habanero (OP)
- Eggplant — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — Florida Market (OP), Black Beauty (H), Ichiban (OP)
- Tomato — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Homestead (OP), Rutgers (H), Cherokee Purple (H), Florida 91 (OP), Mortgage Lifter (H)
- Onion (from seed) — start 10-12 weeks before last frost — Texas Early Grano (OP), Red Creole (H) — short-day varieties for Zone 8 South; intermediate-day for Pacific NW
- Celery — start 10-12 weeks before last frost
- Parsley — start 8-10 weeks before last frost

Direct Sow This Month:

- Peas — ST: 40 F — direct sow January in Zone 8; Sugar Snap (OP), Wando (OP)
 - Spinach — ST: 35 F — direct sow; harvest before spring heat
 - Radish — ST: 40 F — direct sow
 - Lettuce — ST: 40 F — Black Seeded Simpson (OP), Jericho (OP) (heat-tolerant)
 - Arugula — ST: 40 F
 - Carrots — ST: 50 F — late January
 - Beets — ST: 50 F — late January
 - Turnip — ST: 40 F
-

February

Indoor Start This Month:

- Cucumber — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Ashley (H), Poinsett 76 (OP) — heat-tolerant varieties
- Squash, Zucchini — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Yellow Crookneck (H), Dark Star (OP)
- Melon — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Hale's Best (H), Ambrosia (OP)
- Watermelon — start 3-4 weeks before last frost — Crimson Sweet (OP), Charleston Gray (H), Sugar Baby (OP)
- Basil — start 6-8 weeks before last frost
- Broccoli — start 6-8 weeks before last frost (for fall transplant planning, or direct sow now for spring)

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Broccoli, Cauliflower, Cabbage — February transplant is standard in Zone 8 South
- Kale, Swiss chard — transplant or direct sow
- Lettuce — transplant
- Onion sets — plant February
- Leek — transplant
- Potato — plant mid-February through early March — Kennebec (OP), Red Pontiac (OP), Yukon Gold (OP)
- Parsley, Cilantro, Dill — transplant or direct sow

Direct Sow This Month:

- All January direct sow crops continue
 - Dill — ST: 60 F
 - Cilantro — ST: 50 F — last good window before heat causes bolting
-

March

Transplant Outdoors This Month (after last frost, early to mid-March):

- Tomato — harden off 7-10 days; plant after last frost
- Pepper — after last frost, night temps above 55 F
- Eggplant — after last frost, soil above 65 F
- Basil — after frost danger
- Celery — after frost danger
- Herbs (thyme, oregano, sage, rosemary, lavender) — all typically perennial in Zone 8; plant anytime frost-free

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beans (bush + pole) — after last frost, ST: 60 F — Contender (H), Blue Lake (OP), Rattlesnake (H)
 - Corn — ST: 60 F — Truckers Favorite (H), Silver Queen (OP), Stowell's Evergreen (H)
 - Cucumber — ST: 65 F — late March
 - Squash, Zucchini — ST: 65 F — late March
 - Beets, Carrots — succession sow
 - Lettuce — last spring sowing, heat coming
 - Marigold — ST: 65 F
 - Nasturtium — ST: 55 F
 - Chives — ST: 60 F
-

April

Transplant/Direct Sow This Month:

- Cucumber, Squash, Zucchini — transplant or direct sow
- Melon — transplant or direct sow, ST: 65 F
- Watermelon — transplant or direct sow, ST: 70 F
- Pumpkin — direct sow, ST: 65 F — Seminole Pumpkin (H) handles Southern heat
- Sweet potato — plant slips after soil reaches 65 F — Beauregard (OP), Covington (OP), White Bonita (OP) — a primary Zone 8 crop
- Okra — direct sow, ST: 65 F — Clemson Spineless (H), Burgundy (OP), Cow Horn (H) — a staple crop in Zone 8; plant 12-18 inches apart
- Beans — succession sow
- Corn — succession sow
- Sunflower — ST: 55 F
- Southern peas/cowpeas — ST: 65 F — Mississippi Silver (OP), Pinkeye Purple Hull (OP)

Cool season harvest: Peas, broccoli, cauliflower, lettuce, spinach finishing up. Harvest before bolting.

May - June

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beans — succession sow through June
- Corn — last sowing May
- Okra — succession sow
- Southern peas — direct sow
- Sweet potato — last slips planted by late May
- Cucumber — succession sow
- Squash — succession sow; watch for vine borers — Seminole Pumpkin resists them

Note: Cool-season crops are done. Remove spent pea vines, brassicas, lettuce. Transition to heat-tolerant crops.

July - August (Summer Doldrums)

Direct Sow (limited — focus on heat lovers):

- Okra — still producing; succession sow July
- Southern peas — still producing
- Sweet potato — growing strongly
- Beans — heat-tolerant varieties, bush only, early July last sow

Indoor Start (August — fall garden prep):

- Tomato (fall) — start mid-July to early August, 6-8 weeks before fall transplant — Heat Wave II (OP), Solar Fire (OP) — heat-set varieties
 - Pepper (fall) — start mid-July, 8-10 weeks before fall transplant
 - Broccoli (fall) — start 8-10 weeks before transplant (August start, September transplant)
 - Cauliflower (fall) — start 8-10 weeks before transplant
 - Cabbage (fall) — start 6-8 weeks before transplant
 - Kale (fall) — direct sow August or start 6 weeks before transplant
 - Brussels sprouts (fall) — start 8-10 weeks before transplant
-

September

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Fall tomato — transplant early September (Zone 8 South)
- Fall pepper — transplant early September
- Fall broccoli, cauliflower, cabbage — transplant mid-September
- Kale — transplant or direct sow
- Brussels sprouts — transplant

Direct Sow This Month:

- Lettuce — fall/winter crop — Jericho (OP), Buttercrunch (H), Winter Density (OP)
 - Spinach — fall/winter crop
 - Arugula — fall crop
 - Radish — fall crop
 - Carrots — fall/winter crop — harvest through winter
 - Beets — fall crop
 - Turnip — fall crop
 - Peas — late September for fall/early winter harvest
 - Cilantro — fall/winter crop; thrives in cool weather
 - Dill — fall crop
-

October - November

Direct Sow This Month:

- Garlic — plant October through November — Inchelium Red (H, softneck), Creole Red (H), Silver White (H) — softneck varieties preferred for Zone 8; 4-6 inches apart, 1-2 inches deep (shallower than northern zones)
- Spinach — overwintering
- Lettuce — continues producing
- All cool-season greens — direct sow through October

Harvest: Fall tomatoes, peppers, sweet potatoes (dig before hard frost), okra, southern peas.

December

Harvest overwintering greens. Maintain cold frame crops. Minimal dormancy — Zone 8 gardens can produce greens year-round with minimal protection.

Frost date reference — Zone 8 cities:

- Portland, OR: Last frost March 15, First frost Nov 7
- Dallas, TX: Last frost March 14, First frost Nov 17
- Atlanta, GA: Last frost March 21, First frost Nov 13

Zone 9 — Gulf Coast, Southern Texas, Central Florida & SoCal Inland

Last frost date (average): February 10 - March 5

First frost date (average): November 20 - December 15

Growing season length: 260-300 days

Key challenges: Extreme summer heat (100+ F days), intense humidity (Gulf), drought (SoCal/Texas), nematodes, whiteflies, fungal pressure, limited chill hours for some crops, barely any winter dormancy

Season extension tips: The growing season barely stops. The limiting factor is heat, not cold. Focus on heat-tolerant varieties. Plant cool-season crops October through February. Summer = okra, sweet potato, Southern peas, and not much else in the open garden.

January

Indoor Start This Month:

- Tomato — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Homestead (OP), Florida 91 (OP), Cherokee Purple (H), Solar Fire (OP), Tropic (OP) — heat-tolerant varieties critical
- Pepper (sweet) — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — California Wonder (H), Marconi (OP)
- Pepper (hot) — start 8-10 weeks before last frost — Tabasco (H), Datil (H), Habanero (OP)
- Eggplant — start 6-8 weeks before last frost — Florida Market (OP), Ichiban (OP), Ping Tung Long (OP)

Direct Sow This Month:

- Peas — ST: 40 F — Sugar Snap (OP), Wando (OP) — January sow for March harvest
 - Lettuce — direct sow — Jericho (OP), Buttercrunch (H) — prime lettuce season
 - Spinach — direct sow — harvest before April heat
 - Radish — direct sow
 - Arugula — direct sow
 - Carrots — ST: 50 F — Danvers (H), Chantenay (H)
 - Beets — ST: 50 F — Detroit Dark Red (H)
 - Turnip — ST: 40 F
 - Broccoli — transplant (started November) or direct sow — Calabrese (H)
 - Cauliflower — transplant
 - Cabbage — transplant or direct sow
 - Kale — direct sow — Lacinato (H)
 - Swiss chard — direct sow — Fordhook Giant (H)
 - Onion sets — plant January — Texas Early Grano (OP), Red Burgundy (OP) — short-day varieties only
 - Potato — plant mid-January through February — Red LaSoda (OP), Kennebec (OP)
 - Cilantro — direct sow — prime season
 - Dill — direct sow
 - Parsley — direct sow or transplant
-

February

Transplant Outdoors This Month (after last frost, mid to late Feb):

- Tomato — transplant after last frost; harden off 7-10 days
- Pepper — transplant after last frost
- Eggplant — transplant after last frost
- Basil — after frost danger — Genovese (OP), Thai (OP)
- Herbs (thyme, oregano, sage, rosemary, lavender) — perennial in Zone 9; plant anytime

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beans (bush + pole) — after last frost, ST: 60 F — Contender (H), Rattlesnake (H)
 - Corn — ST: 60 F — Truckers Favorite (H), Country Gentleman (H)
 - Cucumber — ST: 65 F — late February — Ashley (H), Poinsett 76 (OP)
 - Lettuce — last spring sowing
 - All cool-season crops — continue harvest/succession sow
 - Marigold — ST: 65 F
 - Nasturtium — ST: 55 F
-

March

Transplant/Direct Sow This Month:

- Cucumber — transplant or direct sow
- Squash, Zucchini — direct sow, ST: 65 F — Yellow Crookneck (H), Costata Romanesco (H), Tatume (H) (heat-tolerant)
- Melon — direct sow, ST: 65 F — Hale's Best (H), Ambrosia (OP)
- Watermelon — direct sow, ST: 70 F — Crimson Sweet (OP), Charleston Gray (H), Jubilee (OP)
- Pumpkin — direct sow, ST: 65 F — Seminole Pumpkin (H) — bred for Southern heat and humidity
- Sweet potato — plant slips after soil reaches 65 F — Beauregard (OP), Covington (OP), Vardaman (OP)
- Okra — direct sow, ST: 65 F — Clemson Spineless (H), Cow Horn (H), Red Burgundy (OP)
- Southern peas — direct sow, ST: 65 F — California Blackeye (OP), Zipper Cream (OP)
- Corn — succession sow
- Beans — succession sow
- Sunflower — ST: 55 F — Mammoth Russian (H)

Cool season wrap-up: Harvest remaining lettuce, spinach, peas, brassicas before they bolt.

April - May

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beans — succession sow through April
- Corn — succession sow through April
- Okra — succession sow; primary summer crop
- Southern peas — succession sow
- Sweet potato — last slips planted by April
- Cucumber — last spring sowing; heat and disease pressure increases
- Squash — last spring sowing; vine borers active May
- Melon, Watermelon — still producing from March sowing

Note: By late April/May, most cool-season crops are finished. Transition fully to heat crops.

June - August (Hot Season)

This is survival gardening. The open garden is hostile territory for most crops.

What's still producing:

- Okra — thrives in heat; harvest daily
- Sweet potato — growing strongly; do not harvest yet
- Southern peas — producing through summer
- Hot peppers — may continue producing
- Basil — heat-tolerant varieties still going

What to do:

- Maintain mulch (4-6 inches) to keep soil from baking
- Shade cloth (50-70%) over any remaining crops
- Water early morning only
- Solarize empty beds with clear plastic to kill nematodes and weed seeds
- Plan fall garden

Indoor Start (July-August — fall garden prep):

- Tomato (fall) — start late July, 6-8 weeks before September transplant — Heat Wave II (OP), Solar Fire (OP), Heatmaster (OP)
 - Pepper (fall) — start late July
 - Eggplant (fall) — start late July
 - Broccoli (fall) — start August
 - Cauliflower (fall) — start August
 - Cabbage (fall) — start August
 - Kale (fall) — start August or direct sow September
 - Brussels sprouts (fall) — start July
-

September

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Fall tomato — transplant early September
- Fall pepper — transplant early September
- Fall eggplant — transplant early September
- Fall broccoli, cauliflower, cabbage — transplant late September
- Brussels sprouts — transplant mid-September
- Basil — fall planting

Direct Sow This Month:

- Beans (bush) — fall crop, ST: 60 F
 - Cucumber — fall crop, ST: 65 F
 - Squash (summer) — fall crop
 - Corn — fall crop, early September
-

October

Transplant/Direct Sow This Month:

- Kale — transplant or direct sow
- Swiss chard — direct sow
- Lettuce — direct sow — winter crop begins
- Spinach — direct sow
- Radish — direct sow
- Arugula — direct sow
- Carrots — direct sow for winter harvest
- Beets — direct sow
- Turnip — direct sow
- Peas — direct sow late October
- Onion sets — plant October
- Cilantro — direct sow — winter cilantro is the best cilantro
- Dill — direct sow
- Parsley — direct sow

Harvest: Fall tomatoes, peppers, eggplant. Dig sweet potatoes before first frost.

November - December

Direct Sow This Month:

- Garlic — plant November through December — Creole Red (H), Ajo Rojo (H), Silver White (H, softneck) — softneck and Creole types preferred; 4 inches apart, 1-2 inches deep
- Continue harvesting winter greens — lettuce, spinach, kale, Swiss chard produce all winter
- Broccoli, cauliflower, cabbage — transplant November if not already in

Zone 9 gardens produce food 12 months a year. The only "off season" is the brutal heat of July-August.

Frost date reference — Zone 9 cities:

- Houston, TX: Last frost Feb 18, First frost Dec 5
- Jacksonville, FL: Last frost Feb 21, First frost Dec 3
- Sacramento, CA: Last frost Feb 24, First frost Nov 26

Zone 10 — South Florida, Coastal Southern California & Hawaii

Last frost date (average): January 31 or earlier (many areas frost-free)

First frost date (average): December 15 or later (many areas frost-free)

Growing season length: 300-365 days (essentially year-round)

Key challenges: Extreme heat and humidity (Florida), salt spray (coastal), nematodes, whiteflies, tropical storms, sandy/alkaline soils (Florida), poor chill hours eliminating many temperate crops, cool-season crops only in "winter"

Season extension tips: The concept reverses entirely. "Season extension" means keeping cool-season crops alive longer into spring using shade cloth and mulch. The summer rainy season (Florida) or dry season (SoCal) is the limiting factor, not cold.

January - February (Prime Cool Season)

This is your best planting window for most vegetables. Use it.

Direct Sow / Transplant This Month:

- Tomato — transplant January (started November) — Homestead (OP), Everglades (H, cherry), Solar Fire (OP), Tropic (OP), Manalucie (OP) — heat-tolerant, disease-resistant varieties mandatory in Florida
- Pepper (sweet) — transplant — California Wonder (H), Cubanelle (OP)
- Pepper (hot) — transplant — Datil (H), Scotch Bonnet (OP), Habanero (OP), Tabasco (H)
- Eggplant — transplant — Florida Market (OP), Ichiban (OP)
- Beans (bush + pole) — direct sow, ST: 60 F — Contender (H), Kentucky Wonder (H)
- Corn — direct sow, ST: 60 F — Silver Queen (OP), Truckers Favorite (H)
- Cucumber — direct sow, ST: 65 F — Ashley (H), Poinsett 76 (OP)
- Squash, Zucchini — direct sow, ST: 65 F — Yellow Crookneck (H), Tatume (H)
- Melon — direct sow February, ST: 65 F — Hale's Best (H)
- Watermelon — direct sow February, ST: 70 F — Crimson Sweet (OP), Sugar Baby (OP), Charleston Gray (H)
- Lettuce — direct sow — Jericho (OP), Buttercrunch (H), Black Seeded Simpson (OP) — prime season; bolts by April
- Spinach — direct sow — Malabar Spinach (OP) handles heat; true spinach only in coolest months
- Kale — direct sow or transplant — Lacinato (H), Red Russian (OP) — grows winter through early spring
- Swiss chard — direct sow — Fordhook Giant (H), Bright Lights (OP)
- Broccoli — transplant (started October-November) — harvest January-February
- Cauliflower — transplant — harvest January-February
- Cabbage — transplant or direct sow
- Carrots — direct sow, ST: 50 F — Short 'n Sweet (OP), Chantenay (H) — short varieties for sandy soil
- Beets — direct sow — Detroit Dark Red (H)
- Radish — direct sow — harvest in 25 days
- Turnip — direct sow
- Arugula — direct sow
- Onion sets — plant January — Granex/Vidalia type (OP), Red Creole (H) — short-day only
- Potato — plant January — Red LaSoda (OP), Yukon Gold (OP) — February harvest possible
- Peas — direct sow January — Sugar Snap (OP) — one of few months cool enough
- Celery — transplant — needs consistent moisture
- Basil — direct sow or transplant — Genovese (OP), Thai (OP) — grows year-round in Zone 10
- Cilantro — direct sow January — only reliable window; bolts fast as temps rise
- Dill — direct sow — Bouquet (OP)
- Parsley — direct sow
- Chives — direct sow or divide
- Herbs (thyme, oregano, sage, rosemary, lavender) — perennial, plant anytime — rosemary and lavender struggle in Florida humidity; better in SoCal
- Sunflower — direct sow — Mammoth Russian (H)
- Marigold — direct sow — year-round pest companion

- Nasturtium — direct sow — prefer cooler months
-

March

Direct Sow / Transplant This Month:

- Okra — direct sow, ST: 65 F — Clemson Spineless (H), Cow Horn (H) — primary summer crop
- Southern peas — direct sow, ST: 65 F — Pinkeye Purple Hull (OP), California Blackeye (OP)
- Sweet potato — plant slips — Beauregard (OP), Covington (OP) — plant March through May
- Beans — last spring sowing
- Corn — succession sow
- Cucumber — succession sow
- Squash — succession sow; vine borers becoming active
- Melon, Watermelon — last planting for spring crop
- Pumpkin — direct sow — Seminole Pumpkin (H) — the only pumpkin worth growing in Zone 10 Florida

Cool season ends: Lettuce, spinach, peas, broccoli, cauliflower — harvest remaining, they're done.

April - May

What's still going:

- Tomato — last harvests before heat shuts them down
- Pepper — may continue producing through summer
- Eggplant — continues producing
- Okra — ramping up
- Southern peas — producing
- Sweet potato — growing
- Beans — final harvest

Direct Sow:

- Okra — succession sow
- Southern peas — succession sow
- Sunflower — succession sow
- Marigold — succession sow

Remove: Spent cool-season crops. Solarize empty beds.

June - August (Hot/Rainy Season)

Minimal planting. Florida enters rainy season. SoCal enters dry season.

What grows:

- Okra — thriving; harvest every 2 days
- Sweet potato — growing underground; patience
- Southern peas — producing
- Hot peppers — some varieties continue
- Basil — still growing
- Malabar spinach — heat-loving vine alternative to true spinach
- Seminole pumpkin — growing

What to do:

- Maintain mulch (4-6 inches minimum)
- Water early morning
- Monitor for pests (whitefly, aphids, spider mites in SoCal)
- Solarize beds for fall planting
- Start fall transplants indoors in August

Indoor Start (August):

- Tomato (fall) — start late August — same heat-tolerant varieties
 - Pepper (fall) — start late August
 - Eggplant (fall) — start late August
-

September

Transplant Outdoors This Month:

- Fall tomato — transplant late September
- Fall pepper — transplant late September
- Fall eggplant — transplant late September

Direct Sow:

- Beans — fall crop
 - Cucumber — fall crop, late September
 - Squash — fall crop, late September
 - Corn — fall crop
-

October - November (Fall Cool Season Begins)

Direct Sow / Transplant:

- Lettuce — direct sow — winter production begins
- Spinach — direct sow (true spinach; Malabar continues from summer)
- Kale — direct sow or transplant
- Swiss chard — direct sow
- Broccoli — transplant (started August-September)
- Cauliflower — transplant
- Cabbage — transplant or direct sow
- Carrots — direct sow
- Beets — direct sow
- Radish — direct sow
- Turnip — direct sow
- Arugula — direct sow
- Peas — direct sow November — Sugar Snap (OP)
- Onion sets — plant November — short-day varieties
- Celery — transplant
- Cilantro — direct sow — fall/winter window
- Dill — direct sow
- Parsley — direct sow
- Potato — plant November for winter harvest

Harvest: Sweet potato (dig October-November). Fall tomatoes, peppers, eggplant.

December

Direct Sow This Month:

- Garlic — plant December — Creole Red (H), Ajo Rojo (H) — Creole varieties best suited to Zone 10; 4 inches apart, 1 inch deep; minimal mulch needed
- Continue all cool-season plantings
- Everything from October/November list continues

Zone 10 never fully stops. The rhythm is: cool-season crops October-March, warm-season crops March-June, survival crops June-September, then back to cool season.

Frost date reference — Zone 10 cities:

- Miami, FL: Frost-free (rare frost events every 10-15 years)
- San Diego, CA: Last frost Jan 29, First frost Dec 15
- Honolulu, HI: Frost-free

Quick Reference: Frost Date Lookup by Major Cities

City	Zone	Avg. Last Frost	Avg. First Frost	Season Length
International Falls, MN	3	May 21	Sept 14	116 days
Duluth, MN	3	May 21	Sept 25	127 days
Bismarck, ND	3	May 14	Sept 22	131 days
Minneapolis, MN	4	May 5	Oct 4	152 days
Burlington, VT	4	May 10	Oct 1	144 days
Madison, WI	4	May 5	Oct 3	151 days
Denver, CO	5	May 5	Oct 6	154 days
Des Moines, IA	5	April 24	Oct 10	169 days
Boston, MA (suburbs)	5	April 26	Oct 16	173 days
St. Louis, MO	6	April 10	Oct 18	191 days
Philadelphia, PA	6	April 10	Oct 24	197 days
Kansas City, MO	6	April 9	Oct 22	196 days
Raleigh, NC	7	April 6	Oct 28	205 days
Oklahoma City, OK	7	April 1	Nov 3	216 days
Seattle, WA (inland)	7	March 24	Nov 11	232 days
Portland, OR	8	March 15	Nov 7	237 days
Dallas, TX	8	March 14	Nov 17	248 days
Atlanta, GA	8	March 21	Nov 13	237 days
Houston, TX	9	Feb 18	Dec 5	290 days
Jacksonville, FL	9	Feb 21	Dec 3	285 days
Sacramento, CA	9	Feb 24	Nov 26	275 days
Miami, FL	10	Frost-free	Frost-free	365 days

San Diego, CA	10	Jan 29	Dec 15	320 days
Honolulu, HI	10	Frost-free	Frost-free	365 days

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You grew food from seed. That's a political act whether you meant it or not. Every tomato you don't buy from a supply chain that treats workers and soil like consumable inputs is a small act of refusal. Keep going.

Companion Planting Chart – \$5

Which plants help each other and which ones fight. Not the recycled internet lists – actual tested combinations with spacing, timing, and the science behind why marigolds really do help your tomatoes. Stop planting basil next to sage just because a blog told you to.

Container Growing Blueprint Pack – \$12

Full growing plans for balconies, patios, fire escapes, and rooftops. Includes soil mixes, container size requirements, watering schedules, and variety recommendations specifically selected for container performance. Designed for people who garden in apartments because that's where they live, not because it's trendy.

Apartment Seed Starting Kit Guide – \$9

How to start seeds in a small space without grow lights that cost more than your rent. South-facing windows, DIY light setups under \$30, soil block makers vs. cell trays, bottom heat on a budget. Everything you need to start 200+ plants in a studio apartment.

Seedwarden makes tools for people who grow their own food. Not lifestyle content. Not aspirational homestead fantasy. Practical information for people doing the work.

All variety recommendations are heirloom or open-pollinated because you should be able to save your own seed. That's not nostalgia – it's self-determination.

Questions? Message us on Etsy. We answer everything.